

Roasted corn and ancho plantain cakes topped with red pepper chipotle cream

Take advantage of fresh corn in season. When it is not available, substitute frozen corn kernels. Plantains, referred to as *cooking bananas*, are blander and less sweet than bananas and are eaten only when cooked. They make an excellent base for many dishes and can be fried, baked, sautéed, and boiled. For this recipe, choose a firm plantain, not an overly soft one.

Red Pepper Chipotle Cream (recipe follows)

4 large ancho chiles

2 cups fresh or frozen corn kernels [250g]

1 tablespoon olive oil

1 small onion, finely chopped

1 large ripe plantain, thinly sliced

1½ cups soy milk or rice milk [375ml]

1 teaspoon salt

Freshly ground pepper

Juice of 1 lime

1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar

2 tablespoons unbleached white flour

6 tablespoons canola or safflower oil, for frying

1. ~~Make~~ the Red Pepper Chipotle Cream 2 hours ahead or the night before.
2. Start a kettle of water boiling. ~~Crack~~ open the chiles and remove the seeds and stems. Place in a heatproof bowl and cover with boiling water. Cover and let stand until the chiles are soft, 20 to 30 minutes. Scrape the meat off the pepper from the inside with the back edge of a knife, leaving the skin behind. Scrape onto a small plate and set aside.

3. In a large dry cast-iron skillet, **toast** the corn over medium-high heat, stirring often, until the kernels are lightly browned, 2 to 3 minutes. Set aside in large bowl.
4. In the same pan, heat the olive oil over medium heat. **Add** the onion and cook until soft and lightly browned, about 5 minutes. Add the plantain and milk and bring to a boil. Reduce the heat to a simmer and cook for 5 minutes. Mash the plantain in the pan with a potato masher until the sauce is thick and chunky. Stir in the chile. Season with the salt and pepper to taste. Continue to simmer 5 minutes longer, stirring occasionally.
5. **Stir** in the lime juice, sugar, and flour; mix well. Add the corn and cook 1 more minute. You should end up with a nice thick batter. Return to a bowl and let cool, then form the batter into 6 equal cakes, about 3 inches [8cm] in diameter.
6. Heat 2 tablespoons of the canola oil in the cast-iron skillet over medium-high heat. **Cook** 2 cakes at a time until browned and crisp on both sides. Repeat the process with 2 more cakes, and so on. You may not need to use all 6 tablespoons of the oil. If you use less oil, you will get a more blackened cake. Serve hot, topped with the chipotle cream.

MAKES 6 CAKES